ironically, just at the moment when Asia has become central to US grand strategy, Washington's influence and power in the region is now significantly challenged, perhaps for the first time since 1945. US policy makers are being tested to formulate a truly effective, comprehensive strategy toward the Indo-Pacific that preserves stability and protects US and allied interests, all in the context of a growing strategic competition between Washington and Beijing, the threat of a nuclear-capable North Korea, and the overall deterioration in international order.

Traditionally, Americans have referred to this region as Asia or the Asia-Pacific, and often have focused on even narrower subregions, such as Northeast Asia or South Asia. Not only have American academic programs in universities similarly divided their studies, but many US government departments split up responsibility for Asia among multiple geographically narrow bureaus. The result has been to limit the ability to conceptualize the area in its totality, including the various linkages that cross ethnic, cultural, and linguistic lines, not to mention the challenges that the region faces. Only recently has it become more prevalent to speak of the Indo-Pacific. This is a relatively new term, intended to provide an integrated sense of the region and its manifold interests. It corresponds largely to the military "area of responsibility" allocated to the US Indo-Pacific Command (see figure 2).[2]

The Indo-Pacific, on this definition, is perhaps the most diverse region on earth. It comprises thirty-six countries that are continental, peninsular, and archipelagic, including tens of thousands of inhabited islands, and covers much of the Pacific and Indian Oceans, as well as the inner seas of Asia. With over three billion people, it contains more than half of the global population, including the world's two most populous nations, India and China, and is where over three thousand languages are spoken. It has the world's largest democracy, India, and two of the world's three largest Muslim nations, India and Indonesia. The Indo-Pacific is home to more than 40 percent of global economic output, including the leading economies of China, Japan, and South Korea. It also contains some of the world's largest and most developed military